

to see if there have been any recent complaints about the business you're inquiring about.

To reduce the amount spent on contractors, be sure to request multiple quotes from those contacts you just collected. And when there's a contractor who quotes a higher price, but makes you feel more comfortable, don't hesitate to show them the other quote and request a price match.

You should also ask for an itemized price list of the entire project, and see what you can do yourself to save money on the final total. We removed and disposed of our own carpet before asking the installers to come, which saved us \$100!

#### **READER TIP:**

*We recently had a plumbing problem that required digging out the yard and replacing part of the line hooking into the city's mainline. We had quotes of \$6,000+, but were fortunate to find a local guy who did it for \$1,500.*

—Jody, NE

## **4. BARTER FOR HELP**

Sometimes you have a project that isn't complex enough to call in a contractor, but you're still not comfortable handling it all by yourself. That's when skilled friends come in handy!

Put out a request on Facebook or check with friends that can help with whatever you need done—woodwork, drywall, plumbing, etc. Many will do so just to be a “good neighbor,” and only require a hot meal, plenty of water, and an occasional batch of cookies in exchange. But if you want to go a step further, buy your friend a gift card to eat out on your tab, and always be ready to lend a hand with whatever skills you might have when they are in need themselves.

## **5. BUY RELIABLE REPLACEMENTS**